

City Routes

Kunming → Dali → Lijiang:

Wind, Flower, Snow & Moon

(6-7 Days)

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Kunming → Dali → Lijiang: Wind, Flower, Snow & Moon (6-7 Days)

Yunnan (云南, "South of the Clouds") is China's most diverse and scenic province -- a land of snow-capped mountains, tropical jungles, alpine lakes, and 25 ethnic minority groups. This 6-7 day route follows the classic "Dali-Lijiang" trail through northwestern Yunnan, connecting three cities that feel like different countries. The journey is especially popular with French travelers -- Yunnan has historical ties to French Indochina, and many local guides speak French.

Cette itinéraire est particulièrement adapté aux voyageurs français.

Day 1-2: Kunming -- Spring City

Day 1: Stone Forest (石林) -- UNESCO World Heritage

A day trip from Kunming (90 km southeast). The Stone Forest is a surreal landscape of towering limestone pillars formed 270 million years ago -- it looks like a petrified forest from another planet. The Sani people (分支 of the Yi ethnic minority) are the local custodians, and their guides share fascinating legends about each formation. The "Greater Stone Forest" (大石林) is the main area with the iconic Ashima rock formation; the "Lesser Stone Forest" (小石林) is quieter and more photogenic. The site is massive -- allow 4-5 hours.

07:00-18:00 | ¥130 | Bus from Kunming East Bus Station (¥34, 1.5 hours) or high-speed rail to Shilin West Station (¥30, 20 min)

Day 1 Evening: Green Lake Park (翠湖公园) & Dianchi Lake (滇池)

Stroll through Green Lake Park -- in winter (November-March), thousands of black-headed gulls from Siberia flock here, creating a magical scene. Then head to

Dianchi Lake (滇池), the "Pearl of the Plateau" -- China's 6th largest lake at 1,886m

elevation. Walk along the Haigeng Park (海埂公园) lakeshore for sunset views across the

water to the Western Hills (西山).

24/7 (park) | Free

Day 2: Crossing Bridge Noodles (过桥米线) & Departure

Before leaving Kunming, try guòqiáo mǐxiàn (过桥米线, Crossing Bridge Noodles) --

Yunnan's most famous dish. The story goes that a scholar's wife invented a system of

keeping soup hot with a layer of oil so she could carry it across a bridge to her studying

husband. The dish arrives as a tray of raw ingredients (sliced chicken, quail eggs,

chrysanthemum petals, rice noodles) that you add to a boiling-hot stone pot of broth.

The oil layer keeps it hot enough to cook everything instantly. Try

Jianxin Garden (建新园)

-- Kunming's most beloved chain since 1906.

07:00-21:00 | ¥25-60/person | Must-try: 过桥米线 (状元过桥米线 for the full experience)

Day 3-4: Dali -- Wind, Flowers, Snow & Moon

Getting There: HSR Kunming → Dali

The Kunming-Dali high-speed rail line covers 350 km in just 2 hours. Second class: ¥145.

The route passes through stunning mountain scenery -- keep your camera ready as you

cross the Lancang River (澜沧江, upper Mekong) gorge. Arrive at Dali Station (大理站), 20

km south of the Old Town. Take bus 8 or a taxi (¥50) to Dali Old Town.

Day 3: Erhai Lake Bike Ride (环洱海骑行)

Erhai Lake (洱海, "Ear Sea" for its shape) is Dali's crown jewel -- a 250 km² alpine lake at

1,972m elevation, framed by the 4,122m Cangshan mountains. Rent an e-bike (电动车, ¥60-80/day) from your guesthouse and ride the eastern shore. The route from Caicun (才村) through Xizhou (喜洲) to Shuanglang (双廊) is the most scenic stretch -- 60 km of lakeside roads, rice paddies, and Bai minority villages. Stop at Xizhou for the famous Xizhou Baba (喜洲粑粑, a crispy stuffed flatbread -- sweet or savory, both delicious). The lakeside scenery shifts constantly -- fishermen casting nets, women washing clothes at the water's edge, cormorant fishing boats, and snow-capped Cangshan reflected in the still water.

全天 | 电动车 ¥60-80/天 / 喜洲粑粑 ¥10-15

Day 3 Evening: Dali Old Town (大理古城)

The Old Town is a walled city dating to the 8th century Nanzhao Kingdom. Unlike many "ancient towns" in China that are fully reconstructed, Dali retains genuine historical

character -- cobblestone streets, traditional Bai-style whitewashed buildings with painted eaves, and the iconic "Foreigner Street" (洋人街) with cafes and bookshops. The night market on Renmin Lu (人民路) is excellent for street food and handmade crafts. Look for Bai tie-dye (扎染) textiles -- the indigo-dyed fabrics are UNESCO-recognized intangible cultural heritage. Dali is known for its relaxed, bohemian atmosphere -- many artists and writers have moved here from Beijing and Shanghai.

Day 4: Three Pagodas (崇圣寺三塔) & Xizhou Old Town (喜洲古镇)

The Three Pagodas are Dali's most recognizable landmarks -- the central Qianxun Pagoda (千寻塔) stands 69m tall and dates to the 9th century, making it one of the oldest standing structures in southern China. The reflections in the adjacent pool create iconic photo opportunities, especially at sunrise. In the afternoon, visit Xizhou Old Town (喜洲古镇) -- a beautifully preserved Bai minority village 18 km north of Dali Old Town, famous for its traditional architecture and Xizhou Baba flatbread. The Linden Centre

(喜林苑), a restored Bai mansion-turned-boutique-hotel, offers afternoon tea with stunning rice paddy views (¥168/person).

三塔 08:00-18:00 | ¥75

Day 5-7: Lijiang -- Naxi Heritage & Snow Mountain

Getting There: HSR Dali → Lijiang

The Dali-Lijiang railway takes approximately 2 hours. Second class: ¥80. Arrive at Lijiang Station (丽江站), 15 km south of the Old Town. Bus 18 or taxi (¥30-40) to the Old Town.

Day 5: Lijiang Old Town (丽江古城)

A UNESCO World Heritage Site since 1997, Lijiang Old Town is a maze of cobblestone streets, canals, and wooden buildings of the Naxi people (纳西族). The town was founded

800+ years ago and is unique for its system of waterways -- clear spring water flows through every street in stone channels. Climb to the top of Lion Hill (狮子山) or Wangu Tower (万古楼) for panoramic views of the Old Town with Jade Dragon Snow Mountain (玉龙雪山) as backdrop. The town is famous for its nightlife -- Bar Street (酒吧街) has everything from traditional Naxi music to live rock. Daytime is for exploring the quieter backstreets -- find the "Big Water Wheel" (大水车) at the town's north entrance. At night, listen for the Naxi Ancient Music (纳西古乐) performance -- a 500-year-old orchestral tradition unique to the Naxi people.

24/7 | ¥50 (古城维护费, ancient town maintenance fee -- sometimes checked randomly)

Day 6: Jade Dragon Snow Mountain (玉龙雪山)

At 5,596m, Jade Dragon Snow Mountain is the southernmost glacier in the Northern Hemisphere. Take the large cable car (大索道) to the glacier park at 4,506m -- the highest

accessible point. From the top station, climb the wooden boardwalk to 4,680m for jaw-dropping views.

Altitude warning:

Even fit visitors may feel dizzy at this elevation. Rent an oxygen bottle (氧气瓶, ¥50-100) at the base. The Blue Moon Valley (蓝月谷) at the mountain's foot is a turquoise-water valley that looks like a Chinese painting come to life -- don't miss it. Book cable car tickets online 1-2 days ahead -- they sell out!

07:00-18:00 | ¥100 (entry) + ¥120 (large cable car) | ! Book cable car tickets online 1-2 days ahead -- they sell out!

Day 7: Shuhe Ancient Town (束河古镇) & Departure

Shuhe is the quieter, more authentic alternative to Lijiang Old Town -- just 4 km northwest. Once a major stop on the Ancient Tea Horse Road (茶马古道), it retains a

village atmosphere with fewer tourists. Visit the Tea Horse Road Museum

(茶马古道博物馆) to understand how tea from Yunnan's mountains was traded to Tibet

and beyond on horseback for over 1,000 years. The Naxi people's Dongba script (东巴文)

-- the world's only living pictographic writing system -- is displayed throughout town.

Book a Naxi cooking class (¥150-200) to learn dishes like Naxi Baba (纳西粑粑) and baba

chicken (粑粑鸡).

24/7 | Free (no entry fee since 2018)

Optional Day Trip: Lugu Lake (泸沽湖)

If you have an extra day, Lugu Lake (泸沽湖) is a stunning alpine lake on the

Yunnan-Sichuan border, 200 km from Lijiang (4-5 hours by bus, ¥100). Known as the

"Kingdom of Women" (女儿国), it's home to the Mosuo people (摩梭族), one of the last

matrilineal societies in the world. The crystal-clear lake at 2,685m elevation is

surrounded by mountains and small villages. Take a traditional dugout canoe (猪槽船)

ride to the islands. The bonfire party (篝火晚会, ¥30) with Mosuo singing and dancing is a

highlight.

Note:

The road is winding -- take motion sickness medicine.

全天 | ¥70 (entry) | Bus from Lijiang Bus Station (4-5h, ¥100)

Tips for French Travelers

* Visa-Free Transit:

* French passport holders can use the 144-hour (6-day) visa-free transit policy when entering and exiting via different ports. If flying into Kunming and out of Shanghai (or vice versa), you qualify. You must have a confirmed onward ticket to a third country/region.

* Attention: vérifiez les conditions actuelles sur le site de l'ambassade de Chine avant votre voyage.

* French-Speaking Guides:

* Yunnan has a surprising number of French-speaking guides due to the province's historical connections with French Indochina. Book through agencies like Yunnan Exploration (yunnanexploration.com) or China Highlights (chinahighlights.com) and request a francophone guide. In Dali and Lijiang, some guesthouse owners speak French.

* Wine in Yunnan:

* Yunnan has a growing wine industry! The region around Mile (弥勒) produces award-winning Cabernet Sauvignon and rosé at high altitude (1,400m). Try Ao Yun (敖云), China's most prestigious wine (LVMH-owned, ¥2,000+ per bottle), or the excellent local brand Yunnan Red (云南红, ¥50-100). Several wineries near Dali offer tastings -- ask your guesthouse.

* Compared to France:

* Yunnan's diversity is like compressing all of France into one province -- the altitude range (76m to 6,740m at Meili Snow Mountain) creates climates from tropical to arctic.

Dali's lakeside setting is often compared to Annecy; Lijiang's Old Town has a Carcassonne-like medieval charm; Shangri-La (中甸) at 3,200m feels like the French Alps with Tibetan monasteries.

* Budget Estimate:

* ¥4,000-7,000 per person for 7 days (mid-range). HSR tickets total: ¥305 (Kunming-Dali ¥145 + Dali-Lijiang ¥80 + local transport ¥80). Hotels: ¥200-500/night in boutique guesthouses. Meals: ¥40-100/day. Yunnan is significantly cheaper than Shanghai.

* Essential Apps:

* 高德地图 (navigation -- works offline for downloaded regions), 美团 (restaurants & deals), 翻译 (Google Translate with downloaded Chinese pack), 铁路12306 (train booking). Download offline maps for Yunnan -- mobile signal can be patchy in

mountainous areas.

* Best Seasons:

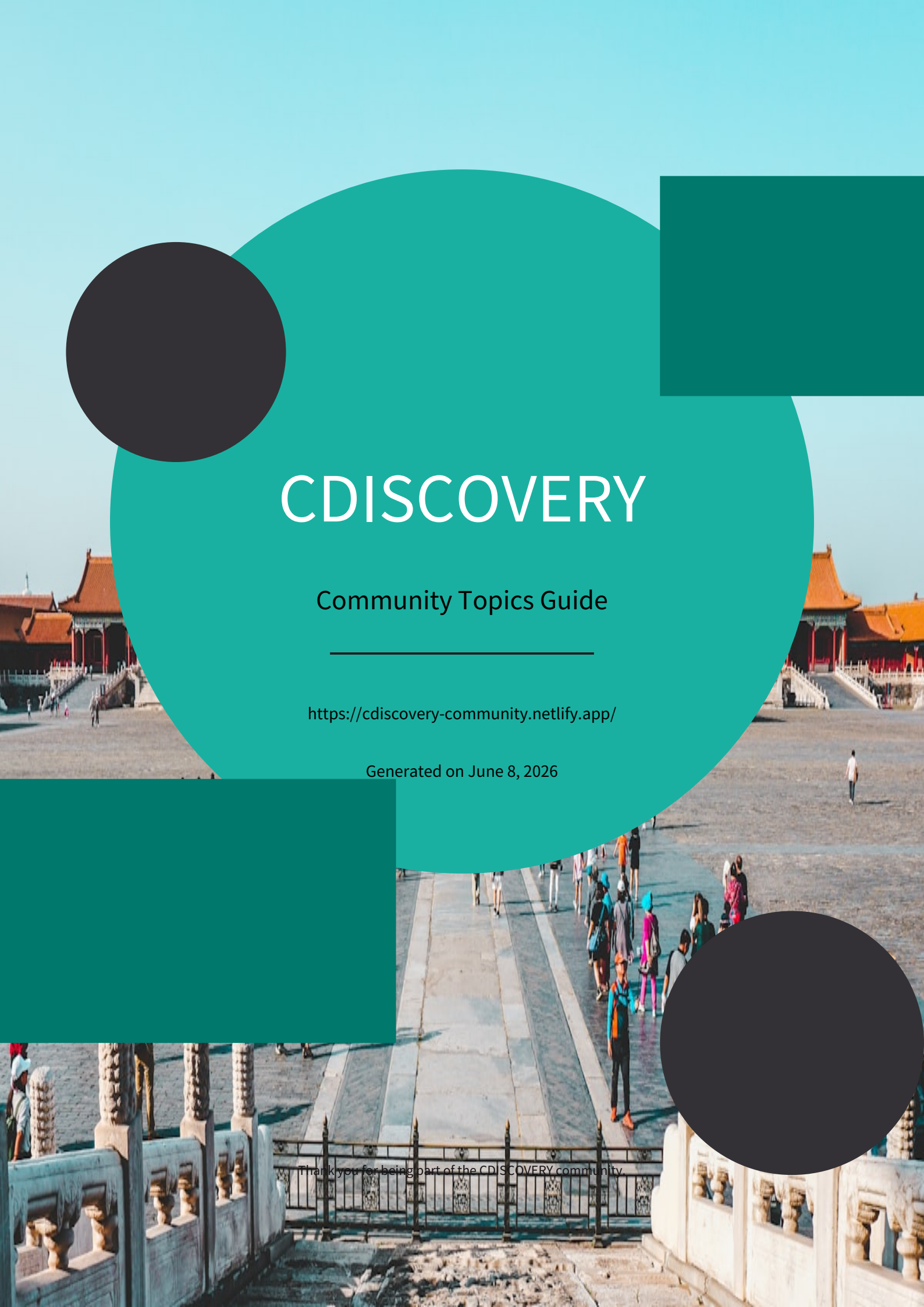
* March-May (spring flowers, clear skies) and September-November (autumn colors, harvest festivals). June-August is rainy season but lush. December-February is cold but sunny -- perfect for snow mountain views. Lugu Lake is most beautiful in spring when the lakeside flowers bloom.

* Altitude Warning:

* Kunming (1,892m), Dali (1,972m), Lijiang (2,416m), and Jade Dragon Snow Mountain (4,506m+). Take it easy the first day at each new altitude. Drink plenty of water. If you feel headaches or dizziness at Jade Dragon Snow Mountain, descend immediately and use the oxygen bottles.

Sources: Sources: [Travel China Guide](https://www.travelchinaguide.com) • [Yunnan Exploration](https://www.yunnanexploration.com) • [UNESCO: Old Town of Lijiang](https://whc.unesco.org/en/list/811) • [UNESCO: South China Karst](https://whc.unesco.org/en/list/1111) • [UNESCO: South China Karst](https://whc.unesco.org/en/list/1111)

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